involved in trade and other non-labour occupations (shipping agents, petty financers, speculators, small traders, men providing services such as barbers) in Colombo and in the plantations was highest from Tirunelveli district. Since migration was circular, the volume of passengers was considerable. As many as 2,50,000 passengers, mostly headed for the tea plantations, passed through the port every year. The quarantine station at Tattaparai was some 15 km away. Elaborate rules and instructions on plague regulations and quarantine were in force at this time.[75] (By the end of the First World War, the newly opened Dhanushkodi–Thalaimannar route across the Palk Straits dramatically reduced the rough crossing between India and Ceylon to a rather calm hour and a half. The quick transit also brought down the fares which the migrant labour naturally preferred. By 1920, the annual traffic on the Tuticorin–Colombo route dwindled to about 20,000 and the daily service was pared down to bi-weekly. On the other hand, well over a 1,00,000 people sailed from Dhanushkodi on the Ceylon Steamship Company's vessels.[76])

As the port grew, Tuticorin became the headquarters of a port officer and of a customs collector. Other officers included a master attendant and superintendent of Pearl Bank and Chank Fishery—over which the government had a monopoly—as well as a sea customs superintendent.[77]

Tuticorin was a division of the Tirunelveli district and its administration included the sub-collector (who was also the joint magistrate), a sub-magistrate, a deputy tahsildar; a sub-registrar; an assistant superintendent of police, and an assistant commissioner of salt and abkari.

As the port expanded, the town grew. In the first decade of the twentieth century its population numbered over 40,000. Tuticorin's importance as a commercial centre far outstripped that of the district headquarters of Palayamkottai/Tirunelveli which was some 50 km away. Apart from the huge Coral Mills, major business firms in the town—all of them European —included Ralli Brothers, New Berar Company, Shaw, Wallace and Company, the Burma Oil Company, the Asiatic Petroleum Company and Dymes and Company. 'Indian traders and brokers—Paravans, Vellalans,